



The UK's AI Skills Ambition

A target, a measurement, and a number nobody can check

Independent research report. Preliminary findings from a project at its research and pilot-design stage. Evidence, inference and opinion are distinguished throughout, and every source is tagged by its likely interest. Interests are declared in §8.

Overview

In June 2025 the government announced a partnership with eleven technology companies to upskill 7.5 million UK workers in AI by 2030. In January 2026 it reported that 1,001,147 courses had been completed, and raised the target to 10 million.

Those courses were delivered by eleven companies: Accenture, Amazon, BT, Barclays, IBM, Google, Intuit, Microsoft, SAS, Sage and Salesforce. The figure counts courses taken by their customers, by their own employees, and through the civil service's internal learning day. No partner-level or course-level breakdowns are published. The Department for Science, Innovation and Technology states that they are not shareable due to commercial sensitivity.

Over the same period the government's own AI skills programme, BridgeAI, recorded 1,700 course completions and 126 accreditations, against £74.6 million allocated from a £100 million budget.

Both sets of numbers are published by the government. Neither appears next to the other.

Several things should be conceded at the outset. A million completions is not nothing. Using training the technology industry already provides free is a legitimate policy choice, not inherently a failure. And when the department published its own estimate of what the programme is worth, it set out the equations behind it and called the result highly uncertain. Most figures in this area come with neither.

What follows is narrower than a verdict on the programme. It asks whether the figures government reports can be checked by anyone outside it, and what happened the last time it published figures of this kind. The argument is built from government's own published material throughout.

The two sets of numbers above come from different programmes with different aims, and this report does not treat them as interchangeable. What they share is that they are where the government's AI skills effort becomes countable. One is reported in specifics: £74.6 million allocated, 1,700 completions, 126 accreditations. The other is reported as a single total, supplied by the eleven companies that delivered it, with the breakdown withheld. The larger number is the one that appears in ministerial forewords.

Nothing in this report shows the million-course figure to be wrong. It shows that nobody outside government is in a position to say.

1. The plan, and the gap nobody had measured

Two documents, published on the same day in January 2025, set the terms for everything that followed. The first is the AI Opportunities Action Plan: an independent report by Matt Clifford, an adviser commissioned by the Secretary of State, presented to Parliament and making fifty recommendations. It commits the government to nothing. The second is the government's reply, which answers the recommendations one by one, and is where the commitments are made.

The plan's skills recommendations run from fifteen to twenty-two. Recommendation 14 comes immediately before them, and it is about whether the size of the problem they address was known at all. It gives one instruction — "Accurately assess the size of the skills gap" — and then explains why.

Current estimates are imprecise and outdated... The success of the following recommendations depends on accurately understanding the skills gap.

— AI Opportunities Action Plan, Recommendation 14, January 2025

The most recent government-funded survey of the AI labour market had been carried out in 2020, five years earlier. The skills dashboard the plan also cites was older still: supply data from 2019.

The government agreed. Responsibility went to Skills England, the executive agency that assesses what skills the country needs. Its reply committed the agency to produce "a clear assessment of the country's skills need – including AI and digital skills – and map pathways by which they can be filled". The date it gave was spring 2025. Skills England had been created in shadow form eight months earlier, in July 2024. It was not fully established until 2 June 2025.

The problem, stated	Estimates "imprecise and outdated". Last survey 2020; dashboard data from 2019.
The commitment	A clear assessment of the country's skills needs, led by Skills England.
Who was to be involved	Businesses, training partners, unions, and national and local government.
How often	"Updated assessments will be published regularly."
Target date given	Spring 2025.

Source: HM Government, *AI Opportunities Action Plan (CP 1241)* and *AI Opportunities Action Plan: government response (CP 1242)*, both 13 January 2025.



NOTE

On the claim that all fifty were accepted

The reply answers each recommendation individually, with its own verdict and target date. Forty-eight were agreed and two partially agreed. The widely repeated claim that all fifty were accepted is very nearly, but not exactly, right.

2. What arrived instead

A survey was commissioned. The AI Labour Market Survey 2025, carried out for the department by the consultancy firm Gardiner & Theobald, states that its findings “contribute to meeting that recommendation”.

119	Organisations responding.
3,940	Organisations contacted.
3%	Response rate, as stated in the report.
50%	Share of respondents based in Greater London.
9	Respondents from Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland combined.

Source: DSIT and Gardiner & Theobald, AI Labour Market Survey 2025, sections 2 and 3. Twenty interviews were conducted, against fifty in the 2020 study.

The survey defines its market as UK organisations “who are commercially developing AI, those who are internally developing AI and those who are procuring AI”. Two thirds of respondents are building AI commercially. It measures the AI industry’s demand for AI professionals.

Its authors state, before any findings are presented, that “self-selection participation to the survey may create a biased sample”. The report also records that its findings “do not represent Government views or policy”.



WHAT THIS DOES NOT CLAIM

This survey is one input, not the whole of the response to Recommendation 14. Government marks that recommendation delivered and names five publications. The point is narrower: the survey covers a far smaller population than the ten-million-worker target names, and its headline percentages are usually quoted without that qualification.

3. A target counted in workers, a figure counted in courses

AI Skills Boost was announced by the Prime Minister at London Tech Week in June 2025 and carries the ten-million-worker target. The AI Skills Hub is its platform. In January 2026 the department published its progress: 1,001,147 courses completed.

The figure covers, in the department's own words, “all AI skills courses delivered by partners since June 2025, from introductory AI literacy to advanced training in areas like data science and machine learning engineering, for both external learners (customers, clients, platform users) and internal learners (partner employees)”.

Unit counted	Courses completed. The target it reports against is expressed in workers.
Supplied by	Eleven commercial partners, self-reported to the department in January 2026.
Who is counted	Customers, clients and platform users, alongside the partners' own employees.
Also included	Courses delivered through One Big Thing, the civil service's internal learning day.
Breakdown published	None. Withheld as commercially sensitive.
Restricted to UK learners	Not stated.

Source: DSIT, AI Skills Boost: explainer, 28 January 2026. The same figure appears in both ministerial forewords to AI Opportunities Action Plan: One Year On, published the following day.

Specific partner or course-level breakdowns of course completion are not shareable due to commercial sensitivity.

— DSIT, AI Skills Boost: explainer, January 2026

Skills England did set a standard. Its AI foundation skills for work benchmark defines six skills across three domains — technical, non-technical, and responsible use — as what a worker needs to use AI competently, and a selection of industry courses on the Hub were checked against it. The million-course figure is not a count of benchmarked courses. It spans everything the partners delivered, including advanced machine-learning training well outside a foundation-skills standard. How much of it meets the benchmark is not published.

4. This has happened before

In April 2020 the Department for Education launched The Skills Toolkit: over £1 million of public money on a page signposting to free online courses from Amazon, Microsoft, LinkedIn, the Open University and Google.

FE Week, the further education trade paper, examined the figures the department was publishing. Registrations included web hits and were not filtered by geography, so could come from anywhere in the world. One provider recorded a completion when a user spent three minutes on a resource. The department later admitted its published completion data might record starts rather than completions.

In March 2021 the Office for Statistics Regulation wrote to the department's chief statistician about unpublished Skills Toolkit figures that had been used to answer Parliamentary Questions. The OSR is the regulatory arm of the UK Statistics Authority, independent of ministers and separate from the departments whose statistics it examines. It sets the standards official statistics must meet, in the Code of Practice for Statistics.

...in future where data are used in the public domain, you will follow the principles of the Code of Practice, in particular ensuring that sufficient methodological detail is available for readers to fully understand the figures.

— Office for Statistics Regulation to the Department for Education, 8 March 2021

Delivery model	Government-branded signposting to free vendor courses. The same in both programmes.
Figures supplied by	The course providers themselves. The same in both programmes.
What “completion” meant	2021: one provider counted three minutes on a resource; the department admitted the figures might record starts. 2026: not defined publicly.
Geographic filter	2021: none; registrations were unfiltered and could come from anywhere in the world. 2026: not stated.
Use in Parliament	2021: inaccurate figures given, and unpublished data used in answers. 2026: cited in two ministerial forewords.
Regulator's involvement	2021: OSR wrote to the department's chief statistician and secured an undertaking on methodological detail. 2026: —

Sources: Office for Statistics Regulation to the Department for Education, 8 March 2021, read directly; FE Week, 29 January and 22 and 25 March 2021; DSIT, AI Skills Boost: explainer, January 2026.

THE EMPTY CELL

One row has no entry for 2026

Every row above has a 2021 entry because a trade paper investigated the figures and a regulator then wrote to the department. For 2026 the questions have been put, but no regulator has examined the figures. That is the difference between the two programmes on the evidence available — not that one is known to be unsound and the other sound.

Sue Pember, policy lead at HOLEX, the adult and community education body, drew the comparison when the new programme launched.

While the ambition is positive, the lesson from the skills toolkit should be that take-up and outcomes matter more than headline registration numbers.

— Sue Pember, HOLEX, quoted in FE Week

The programme also introduced digital badges for course completion. The chair of Skills England described them as “a huge step forward” and “a simple idea that will make a huge difference”. The Open Badges standard was published in 2011.

5. Who supplies the evidence

The AI Skills Hub was built under contract. Innovate UK, the UK's national innovation agency and part of UK Research and Innovation, commissioned PwC to design, build and run it, following what it describes as a robust competitive tender. PwC is also named as a delivery partner of the programme.

Separately, Innovate UK's February 2026 white paper says its figures were drawn mainly from large datasets, including the PwC Global CEO Survey, the AI Jobs Barometer and the Global Hopes and Fears Survey. All three are PwC's, and PwC surveys are cited three times in the paper's own argument for the scale of the skills gap.

So one commercial firm built the platform, helps deliver the programme, and supplies much of the evidence that the platform is needed. Competitive tendering is how public contracts are normally awarded, and nothing here suggests anything improper. The question is not whether the process was fair. It is whether the evidence is independent.

The same pattern appears further up. The economic case is carried by a single figure: AI adoption could add £400 billion to the UK economy by 2030. It is cited across government communications and in the Action Plan itself, where it is footnoted to Public First's Google's Impact in the UK 2023. The same consultancy separately produced a UK AI economic report commissioned by Microsoft. Neither observation requires assuming anyone acted in bad faith. Both mean the evidence base is more concentrated in interested parties than its presentation suggests.

No response from Innovate UK, PwC, Digital Catapult or DSIT to these observations has been sought at the time of writing. That is a gap in this report and should be closed before these findings are treated as settled (see §8).

6. What the evidence says would work

The government has already commissioned an answer to what good AI training looks like. What Works for AI Upskilling in the UK, published in June 2026 by Dr Nisreen Ameen of Royal Holloway in partnership with Skills England, drew on 23 workshops with around 150 organisations, ten case studies and a survey of 536 decision-makers. From that it derives PRIMES: six principles for designing AI training, written for employers, each with its own accreditation-style criteria. The name is the six principles — practical, reachable, integrated, modular, expandable, sustainable — and each row below adds one concrete requirement from them.

Its authors are explicit about the limits. The survey ran through Amazon Mechanical Turk, skews towards London-based and AI-engaged organisations, and is not offered as a representative national picture.

Practical	Links to real tasks; recognises existing informal AI use rather than assuming a zero starting point; states when AI should and should not be used.
Reachable	Accessible in time, format and language; designed around intersecting barriers of income, age, disability and gender, not a single average learner.
Integrated	Fits existing systems and standards; mandatory before staff use AI on regulated, confidential or safety-critical work.
Modular	Short, stackable units of 30–90 minutes, with entry at different levels and clear return points.
Expandable	Builds transferable skills across tools and roles rather than single-vendor competence.
Sustainable	Reviewed on a set cadence, with 3- and 6-month revisits; tracks confidence and quality of judgement, not just enrolment.

PRIMES says what training should cover. It says less about the order. For that, the useful pattern comes from classroom teaching rather than AI research: the Gradual Release of Responsibility model, where the instructor models the task, then guides practice, then the learner works alone. It is general instructional design, offered here as a sequence rather than as evidence about AI.

Separately, evidence on AI literacy training suggests it can improve how well people judge their own confidence. That matters because surface familiarity with AI can increase misplaced trust rather than reduce it.

None of this is hypothetical. Elements of AI, from MinnaLearn and the University of Helsinki, is vendor-neutral, needs no technical background, and is built as short chapters combining theory, exercises and self-reflection. It has reportedly reached around a million learners. That is evidence of reach, not of measured learning outcomes.

Elements of AI reports around a million learners since 2018. The UK's eleven-partner programme reports 1,001,147 courses since June 2025. A single free university course has reached roughly what eleven companies and a government programme report between them.

7. Where this project fits

Grounded AI Practice is an independent research project, not a competitor to a national platform. It has no platform and no learners yet: it is at the stage of deciding what to build first, and of testing that decision against evidence rather than assuming it. Nothing below proposes replacing what this report examines. It records what the project has decided to do differently, and why. Its working decisions to date:

Initial audience	Individuals seeking practical everyday AI literacy, with particular attention to employees at small organisations who lack the employer-provided L&D infrastructure that both PRIMES and the AI Skills Hub assume.
First output	A single pilot learning unit — not a roadmap, course library or platform — sized to PRIMES' modular criterion and sequenced accordingly, tested with real learners before anything wider is built.
Pilot capability	Effective prompting, chosen to show a learner the gap between what they type and what the model actually does with it, while teaching an immediately usable skill.

The gap in scale between this project and a national programme is not something to apologise for. It is the reason the project can do something the programme cannot. A programme carrying a ten-million-worker target has to launch at scale; it cannot easily run one small unit with a handful of learners, find that it does not work, and rebuild it. A project that has not launched can do exactly that. The evidence above suggests that step — build small, test, rebuild — is the one that was skipped.

8. Method, limitations and declared interests

Findings here draw on primary sources read directly wherever possible. The AI Opportunities Action Plan and its government response, the AI Skills Boost explainer, One Year On, the AI Labour Market Survey 2025, the government's per-recommendation delivery tracker, the Office for Statistics Regulation's March 2021 letter and both Innovate UK documents were obtained and read. Every source is tagged by its likely interest so that concentration in the evidence base is visible rather than hidden. Where a finding would materially affect this project's direction, confirming and disconfirming evidence was sought together.

Specific limitations, stated directly:

- No response has been sought from Innovate UK, PwC, Digital Catapult or DSIT. The observations in §5 are one-sided until that is done, and it should be done before publication rather than after.
- The Office for Statistics Regulation's March 2021 letter has been read directly. §4's account of what was wrong with the Skills Toolkit figures rests on FE Week's reporting, and the £1 million cost figure has not been traced to a departmental publication.

- The AI Labour Market Survey is one of five publications government names as delivering Recommendation 14, not the whole of it. Two of the five have not been read, and no delivery status on the government's tracker has been independently verified: that tracker is DSIT and Number 10 scoring their own plan.
- All BridgeAI delivery figures are self-reported. The year-three review they come from was produced by Digital Catapult, part of Innovate UK's own Catapult Network, for Innovate UK. No independent audit or evaluation of BridgeAI or the AI Skills Hub has been located.
- The £400 billion figure's underlying model has not been independently reviewed. Its provenance has been traced through the Action Plan's own footnote; the Google-commissioned report itself has not been read.
- The June 2025 announcement that set the original 7.5 million target was read through a text extraction rather than in full, and the Prime Minister's London Tech Week speech of 9 June 2025 has not been read at all. The AI Skills Boost explainer attributes the 10 million target to that speech; the announcement itself and the government's delivery tracker both record 7.5 million.
- Whether the 1,001,147 figure is restricted to UK learners is unknown. A Freedom of Information request on that, on the internal and external learner split, and on the operational definition of “completed”, is the obvious next step and this project intends to make one.

Declared interests

This report is published by a project that proposes an alternative approach to the one it examines. That is a real interest and is declared plainly: the author benefits if this analysis is found persuasive. Readers should weigh the evidence accordingly, which is why the argument is built as far as possible from government-published material that can be checked independently.

The project has received no funding, sponsorship or support from any organisation named in this report, and holds no commercial relationship with any of them.

Sources

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Full source list, interest tagging and entry-by-entry findings are maintained in the Grounded AI Practice project repository.